Recommendations Brief

Keep, Change, Explore with 90-Day Priorities | March 23, 2026

Executive Summary

This brief consolidates findings from the Pre-Engagement Assessment, 7 stakeholder interviews, market research, and synthesis work into a clear action plan. The recommendations are grounded in what Horicon Bank already does well and designed to work within existing tools, team capacity, and budget.

The goal: fewer priorities, deeper impact, and a frontline that can articulate why Horicon Bank matters.

Keep, Change, Explore

Keep (Validated Strengths to Protect and Scale)

Use these assets as your competitive foundation. They work. Scale them where it counts.

1. "Together. Doing Good." – Universal Stakeholder Support

Operational proof points exist (CHRE virtues, 40 hrs volunteer time, trust seminars). Works in both retail and business contexts. The narrative connects to community involvement, the 130th anniversary, and the culture.

2. Senior Programs (Established Stewards)

0% failure rate on Glider journeys. Trust seminars averaging 100 attendees. Estate planning and funeral trust partnerships. Minimal competition in SE Wisconsin. This is a proven, scalable program.

3. Tech Stack Investments

Total Expert, Alkami, AnalyzerIQ, Vertical IQ. Where deployed, performance is strong. The platform is not the problem.

4. Nonprofit Checking Strategy

Interest-bearing nonprofit checking is unique. Recent nonprofit brought ~$1M deposits. Board members represent HNW cross-sell opportunity.

5. 130th Anniversary Narrative

Using longevity as a trust signal, especially in Milwaukee expansion. "Old and new" positioning works in urban markets.

6. My Money Youth Checking

Auto-transition at 18, debit limit increases. Competitive response to Greenlight. Foundation for First-Generation Builders persona.

Change (Validated Gaps Requiring Action)

These shifts are necessary to tighten strategy and improve execution readiness. They're not overhauls—they're refinements.

1. Retire "The Natural Choice" as Primary Position

Keep in legacy Dodge County markets only. "The Natural Choice" requires geographic context that Milwaukee and Fox Valley don't have.

2. Consolidate 13 Segments to 4 Personas

Move from demographic segmentation to aspiration-first personas: Established Stewards, Growing Families, First-Generation Builders, Business Owners.

3. Restructure Marketing Allocation into Budget

Current $1.5-1.6M is allocation, not budget. 70% to events is too high. Restructure: Cash in Market (persona-driven campaigns), Brand Maintenance (cap 30%), Market Research (testing/flex).

4. Build Post-Event Nurture Sequences

Currently missing across all programs. Events generate attendance but no systematic follow-up. Total Expert can automate this.

5. Activate Personas for Frontline

Currently known only to senior management. Must be simplified and embedded in daily tools and conversations. Name them in language frontline uses.

Explore (Opportunities to Validate in 90-Day Sprint)

These are high-potential plays with early signal. Validate them in the next 90 days.

1. Youth Banking as 90-Day Sprint Persona

Two stakeholders independently named this. Product ready. 52% Gen Z choose banks on values. Themed digital banking app with financial literacy.

2. Senior Prospect Acquisition in Milwaukee

Current programs are retention-focused in legacy markets. Convert to prospect acquisition events in SE Wisconsin.

3. Bank at Work 2.0

Redesign around Business Owner persona. Lead with employee financial wellness, not product features. Coordinate consumer and commercial teams.

4. Digital Geo-Targeting for Milwaukee

No billboards. Limited digital ad geo-tracking. Erik: "Impressions are fine but they don't mean anything. We need links that are clicked."

90-Day Priorities (The Action Plan)

Eight priorities with clear owners, timelines, and success metrics. These are the 90-day moves that compound into strategic wins.

Priority	Owner	Timeline	Persona	Success Metric
Launch My Money youth campaign	Rose + Natalie	Days 1-30	First-Gen Builders	50 new My Money accounts in 90 days
Deploy Glider prospect journey in Total Expert for Milwaukee	Danielle + Kerry	Days 1-45	Established Stewards	3 prospect acquisition events, 25 new leads
Restructure marketing budget into 3 categories	Rose + Erik	Days 1-30	All	Budget document with persona allocations
Build post-event nurture sequence in Total Expert	Danielle	Days 15-45	All	Automated follow-up for every event by day 45

Priority	Owner	Timeline	Persona	Success Metric
Simplify persona names and create frontline one-pagers	BrandThnk + Rose	Days 1-15	All	One-pagers distributed to all branches
Bank at Work 2.0 pitch deck with employee benefit framing	Erik + Rose	Days 30-60	Business Owners	5 new Bank at Work conversations
Website audit and mobile-first updates for younger demographics	Natalie	Days 30-90	First-Gen Builders, Growing Families	Updated landing pages for 2 personas
"Together. Doing Good." messaging spine deployed	BrandThnk delivery	Days 1-30	All	Messaging document + branch talking points

Messaging Spine

This is the architecture that guides near-term execution. It connects your brand position to each persona's aspirations.

Brand Position: Together. Doing Good.

Supporting Proof Points:

- 130 years of community banking
- CHRE virtues (Capability, Honesty, Respect, Energy)
- 40 hours paid volunteer time for every employee
- Trust services and estate planning expertise
- Local decision-making, not corporate committees

Persona-Specific Messages

Established Stewards

"You spent decades building something. We'll help you protect it, grow it, and pass it on. Our trust team has been doing this since before most fintechs existed."

Growing Families

"Between the mortgage, the kids' accounts, and the insurance, you need a bank that sees the whole picture. We're not a feature list. We're your financial partner."

First-Generation Builders

"Your first real bank should be one that shares your values. We're not an app. We're a 130-year community that's still growing, just like you."

Business Owners

"You need a bank that understands your business, not just your balance sheet. Together, we'll build something that works for your employees and your bottom line."

What Happens Next

> **Week of March 23:** Recommendations Brief delivered (this document)

> **Week of March 30:** Working Session #1 with Rose and leadership. Pressure-test personas, validate priorities.

> **Week of April 6:** Working Session #2. Draft messaging spine review. 90-day plan refinement.

> **Week of April 13:** Final deliverables package. Persona one-pagers, messaging spine, 90-day activation playbook, budget restructuring template.

> **April 14+:** Execution begins. BrandThnk available for check-ins.

"The goal isn't more documentation. It's confidence in the path forward. Horicon Bank has the culture, the tools, and the team. What's been missing is focus. These recommendations provide that focus: fewer personas, clearer messaging, and a 90-day plan that turns strategy into action."

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